

Session 23: Tabernacle Furniture

Key Takeaways

- The tabernacle instructions are framed as a series of seven speeches by Yahweh.
- The tabernacle instructions echo the themes and narrative elements of the creation story in Genesis.
- The richness and splendor of the tabernacle increase as you approach the innermost holy place.

Time in the Tabernacle Texts

Exodus 24:15-18 NIV

¹⁵ When Moses went up on the mountain, the cloud covered it, ¹⁶ and the glory of the LORD settled on Mount Sinai. For six days the cloud covered the mountain, and on the seventh day the LORD called to Moses from within the cloud. ¹⁷ To the Israelites the glory of the LORD looked like a consuming fire on top of the mountain. ¹⁸ Then Moses entered the cloud as he went on up the mountain. And he stayed on the mountain forty days and forty nights.

We gain theological insight when we pay attention to the elapse of time on the mountain. During this time of testing in the wilderness (40 days/nights ≈ 40 years), God does a new work of creation (six days), and he invites his people into sabbath rest (seventh day) by which he lives among them again.

Creation Echoes in the Tabernacle Texts

The tabernacle instructions recall [Genesis 1-3](#) imagery and themes.

- Culminates in consecration ([Gen. 2:3](#); [Exod. 40:9-13](#))
- Cherubim as guardians of sacred space ([Gen. 3:24](#); [Exod. 25:18](#), [26:1](#))
- Tree of life and the lampstand with seven branches ([Gen. 2:9](#); [Exod. 25:31-37](#))
- Gold and onyx stones ([Gen. 2:12](#); [Exod. 26:37](#), [28:5-6](#), [9](#), [17-20](#))
- “Evening” and then “morning” ([Gen. 1:5](#); [Exod. 27:21](#))
- Prescribed food and proscribed food ([Gen. 2:16-17](#); [Exod. 29:31-34](#))
- God’s Spirit, knowledge, and skill in creation ([Gen. 1:2](#); [2:2-3](#), [7](#), [17](#); [Exod. 31:3](#))
- Seven-day process ([Gen. 1](#); [Exod. 29:30](#); [Lev. 8:33](#))
- Clothing the “priests” ([Gen. 3:21](#); [Exod. 28:41](#))

Time in the Tabernacle Texts

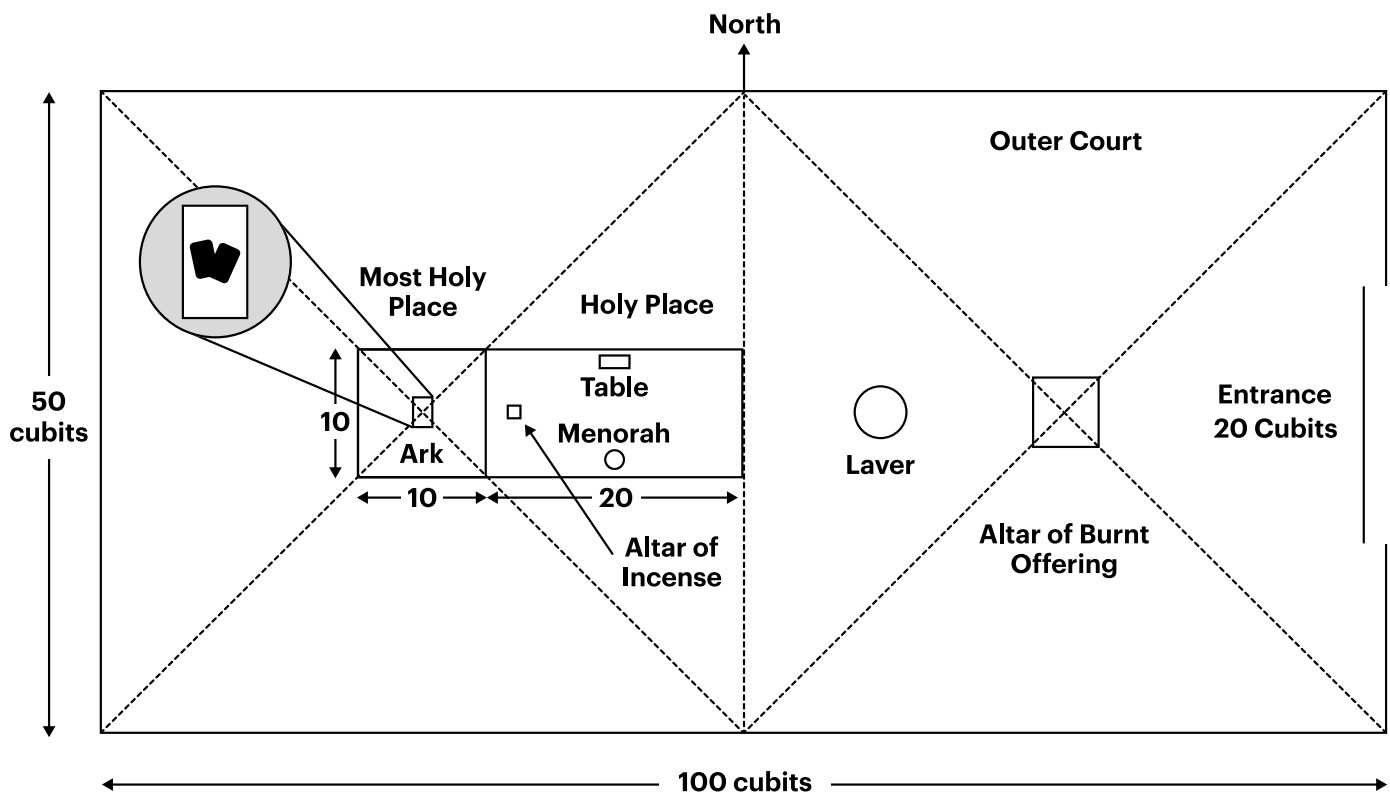
YHWH’s instructions are presented as seven speeches (Exod. 25-31).

1. Tabernacle and furnishings (Exod. 25:1-30:10)
2. Atonement money (Exod. 30:11-16)
3. Wash basin (Exod. 30:17-21)
4. Anointing oil (Exod. 30:22-33)
5. Incense recipe (Exod. 30:34-38)
6. Appointing Bezalel and Oholiab (Exod. 31:1-11)
7. Sabbath (Exod. 31:12-17)

Narrative Space in the Tabernacle Texts

The two objects that take up the most narrative space, where the biblical author slows down to provide exquisite details, are the ark of the covenant and the breastplate of the high priest.

Sacred Space in the Tabernacle Texts



Tabernacle Dimensions and Layout. Diagram by Danny Imes. Imes, Carmen Joy (2018). *Bearing YHWH's Name at Sinai*. Eisenbrauns. 125.

The outside curtains are white, with the east-west axis using the most elaborate fabrics. The expense and beauty of materials increase as you approach the most holy place.

Reflection Question

Reflect on the connection between the tabernacle and creation/garden imagery. What shared themes do you notice? What is the significance of this connection?